General rule – armor and shields · "Equipment" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

The Shield. It is its own armor category. It gives a **+2 bonus to AC**, costs **10 GP** and weighs **6 lb**. You can benefit from only **one shield at a time**. A magic shield (+1, +2, +3) adds its bonus.

Training. You must have training with shields. Without it, you have **Disadvantage** on any D20 Test involving Strength or Dexterity (attacks, checks, saves) and you **can't cast spells**.

Donning and doffing. It takes the **Utilize** action to don a shield, and another to doff it.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Check that the character is **trained** with shields.
2. **Don it** with the Utilize action (one hand).
3. Add **+2** to AC.
4. In combat, attacking with it doesn't remove the bonus.
5. To **doff**: Utilize action.

⚠ Change from 2014

The 2024 text clarifies that donning and doffing a shield uses the **Utilize** action; light, medium, and heavy armor take longer.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say how to **set down** a shield without doffing it, or whether you can swap one mid-combat. Fix: the DM announces beforehand what is allowed.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe straps tightening on the forearm, metal ringing under the blow, the weight pulling the arm.

Step 1 – Check training:

Only classes trained with shields can use them without penalty (see the table). Without training: Disadvantage on Strength/Dexterity and **no spells**.

Step 2 – Don the shield:

Utilize action. The shield occupies one hand: a two-handed weapon can't be wielded two-handed with it.

Step 3 – Compute AC:

Armor's AC + 2. No armor: 10 + Dexterity modifier + 2. The **Barbarian's Unarmored Defense** allows a shield; the **Monk's** doesn't. The *Mage Armor* spell works with a shield.

Step 4 – In combat:

Attacking with a shield doesn't remove its AC bonus. The shield isn't a weapon: the SRD gives no attack profile.

Step 5 – Spells and hands:

A free hand is needed for **Material** components or the **focus**; the same hand serves for **Somatic** components. An **emblem engraved on a shield** can serve as a holy symbol.

Step 6 – Doff the shield:

Utilize action. A donned shield is **worn**, not merely held: you don't drop it for free.

Example: Mira (Cleric, AC 16) dons her shield with the Utilize action: AC 18. She attacks with her mace: the bonus stays. To cast Cure Wounds, she needs a free hand: she doffs the shield, or uses the emblem on it as a focus depending on the spell.

Donning times:

Type	Don	Doff
Light armor	1 minute	1 minute
Medium armor	5 minutes	1 minute
Heavy armor	10 minutes	5 minutes
Shield	**1 action (Utilize)**	**1 action (Utilize)**

Training by class:

Class	Shield training
Barbarian, Cleric, Druid, Fighter, Paladin, Ranger	Yes
Bard, Monk, Rogue, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard	No

A multiclassed character gains the new class's training following the multiclassing rule (limited training).

⚠ Common questions:

How long does it take to don a shield?

One action (Utilize). Same to doff.

Can I wear two shields?

No: one shield at a time.

What bonus does a shield give?

+2 to AC. A magic shield adds its own bonus.

What happens without training?

Disadvantage on any Strength or Dexterity D20 Test, and no spells.

Does a shield hinder spells?

Not if you're trained. You need a free hand for Material components or the focus.

Can a Monk use a shield?

The Monk's Unarmored Defense requires no armor and no shield.

Can a Barbarian use a shield?

Yes: its Unarmored Defense forbids only armor.

Does an SRD feat concern shields?

No SRD feat is about shields.

⚠ Debate points and table options:

Table rule

Setting the shield down

The SRD only covers "don / doff". **Option**: drop the shield like an object, no action.

Swapping shields

Two actions (doff then don). **Option**: keep it.

Improvised shield

A shield isn't a weapon. **Option**: use it as an improvised weapon.

Shield and climbing

The shield occupies a hand. **Option**: the DM may impose Disadvantage or have it stowed.

Two-handed with a shield

You can't wield a two-handed weapon with a shield. **Option**: keep it.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Attacking with a shield

Attacking with a shield doesn't remove its AC bonus.

Mage Armor

A shield can accompany *Mage Armor*.

Unarmored Defense

The Monk's forbids armor and shield; the Barbarian's forbids only armor.

Donned shield

It is worn, not merely held: you can't make someone drop it like a weapon.

Emblem and hands

A Cleric with an emblem on their shield can cast a Material-component spell while holding a mace; a spell with no component needs a free hand.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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